

Benchmark Pre-Intensive, Reflective Journal

Raymond Wagoner

School of Behavioral Sciences, Liberty University

Author Note

Raymond Wagoner

I have no known conflict of interest to disclose.

Correspondence concerning this article should be addressed to Raymond Wagoner. Email:

rdwagoner1@liberty.edu

Abstract

This paper is a synthesis of the material in Svinicki and McKeachie (2014), West et al. (2013), Arghode et al. (2017), and Freeman et al. (2019). These texts include descriptions of roles and responsibilities in counselor education, pedagogy methods, models of adult learning, instruction and curriculum design, delivery and evaluation, effective approaches to online learning, screening, remediation, and gatekeeping functions relevant to teaching, assessment of learning, ethical and cultural issues related to counselor preparation, and the role of mentoring in counselor education. The reflective summary of this paper will describe how each of these areas affects counselor educators, emerging counselors, and higher education in general.

Keywords: pedagogy, adult learning methods, instructional design in higher education, theories of education

Benchmark Pre-Intensive, Reflective Journal

Becoming a counselor educator is neither a tapping into innate skills nor a mindless pastime. Learning to be a counselor educator is an intentional and proactive undertaking. Four research sources and experiences have been reviewed to aid in this undertaking. Nine areas of what it means to be a counselor educator have been assessed and synthesized in reviewing these sources. What follows is a discussion of the synthesis of those nine areas.

Roles and Responsibilities in Counselor Education

Three of the four sources reviewed for this assignment have cited multiple applications and outcomes related to educating counselors. One of the best examples is on page 48 of West et al. The table in figure 4.1 synthesizes the roles and responsibilities of the counselor educator. Among these roles and responsibilities in this table and represented throughout the reading (F, 209; S, 8, 14, 19-25, 53, 72, 91, 109, 111, 128, 166-169, 207, 322-325; W, 14, 17, 18, 20, 23, 28, 43, 46, 48, 53, 54, 71, 76, 77, 117) are guide, facilitator, one who gives definitions, one who articulates, model, observer, assessor, evaluator, resource, one who theorizes, and one who is a constant learner.

These roles and responsibilities are not always evident or understood, nor should they be assumed (F, 209; W, 15-17). It is incumbent upon the instructor to ensure that they have clear roles and responsibilities and are communicating those roles and responsibilities to peer faculty, faculty supervisors, and students (S, 8, 14, 331-337; W, 16). The functions of counselor educators take on a thematic nuance in that they should be aware of and able to use the skills they have learned as a counselor in the relationships and education of emerging counselors (W, 20, 125-136). There is little use in developing interpersonal skills that are not applied to educating future life-changers. That conclusion is based on West et al. and the constant

admonition to take the tools and theories of change and apply them to the graduate classroom. Specific outcomes related to roles and responsibilities should be addressed at all levels of organization and preparation according to West et al. and Svinicki and McKeachie; however, roles and responsibilities of educators inform and interact with all the remaining areas, including pedagogy methods.

Pedagogy Methods

According to two sources, a teacher's responsibilities are multi-faceted and multi-dimensional (S, 19-25; W, 6). But the theories and subjects' pedagogy are responsible to and responsible for are not as crucial as the personalities and relationships represented by those theories and topics (W, 51-66). Regardless of the method of the pedagogy (lecture, group discussions, inter-student assignments, virtual or in-person, communication, or professional involvement), what the sources point to is the importance of experience connecting to action (W, 51-68), excitement for the subject modeled by the instructor (W, 23), student-centered learning (S, 22), experiential learning as sustainable change (S, 53), emotion as part of learning and the importance of demystifying emotion in the classroom and in how students learn (S, 315), and modeling all aspects of what is being taught by the instructor (W, 158).

Of these functions of pedagogy, Bloom's taxonomy, and the revisions by Anderson et al. (S, 309-310), the theory of learner-centered teaching (S, 306), using Kolb's approach to shaping pedagogy methods (S, 314; W, 52), and Damasio's argument that we cannot deconstruct the human elements to prefer one part over the other (S, 314) provide the framework for staying focused on where teaching orthodoxy intersects teaching orthopraxy. And these guides permit us to adapt old orthopraxy and adopt new methods of teaching that work for the current and future generations. Although the consensus from the data presented seems to be that teaching students

how to learn is more important than adapting to changes in generational thinking (S, 174). With this in mind, the following section describes more of how models of adult learning shape pedagogy.

Models of Adult Learning

Rather than trying to answer the age-old question of which came first, the chicken or the egg, the better concept of the overlap in pedagogy and adult learning seems closer to two sides of the same coin (A, 603). When conceptualizing or theorizing about adult learning, one needs to consider how we are teaching and whether the teaching is engaging and effective (A, 605). To do this, one should ask questions about good learning theories and decide if they improve learning (A, 605) or if they are just good concepts (S, 33). Then, as Arghode et al. (605) discovered, learning theories must define effective learning and build models of pedagogy based on that definition. For these concepts to make their way from whiteboard to classroom success, Svinicki and McKeachie (33) suggest four questions for meta-analysis of learning. The first question, similar to Arghode et al.'s concept (605), is how does the theory describe learning? Then, like scaffolding, what must happen for that learning to occur? Third is where pedagogy intercepts the theory as one asks how to design instruction. And lastly, is it generalizable, or do further qualifications need to be made for audience and circumstance?

Regardless of the theory and model, several key concepts about adult learning pervade the sources in question. First, the most profound outcomes are born from teaching students how to learn (S, 315). Teachers are not simply presenters of information; they are, more importantly, creators of students (W, 55-66). To do this, the sources suggest creating community among students ((S, 22), using mindful learning (S, 30-31), and building relationships with students

from the beginning of class (W, 18). From these concepts, instruction methods and curriculum design can flow.

Instruction and Curriculum Design, Delivery, and Evaluation

Regarding instruction, the central encouragement from the sources is to stay creative (A, 603; S, 316; W, 14). Staying innovative in the classroom means that the design and delivery of the curriculum need to be integrated and tied to the goals of the course (S, 74, 268; W, 14). It also means that evaluation should be purpose-driven according to the setting and different learners and not static nor for grading purposes only (S, 74). With these notions in mind, a creative instructor can adjust to various courses, materials, settings, and students by realizing that (especially in counselor education (W, 27)) the relationship with the student should guide all the above. Being creative and integrative also means using group learning (S, 191-201), case-based instruction (S, 208), reflecting on experience (S, 204), writing in the classroom and out of the classroom (S, 213-230, W; 67), and utilizing other means of instruction besides lecture (W, 53-54).

Communication is another critical element to staying creative and keeping students on track (W, 14). When students are unaware of why an instructor is employing a particular tactic or evaluation method, they can become irritated or disenchanted (S, 186). Communicating from day one with goals, objectives, why specific assignments were chosen, and when higher order thinking skills are the goal can help students understand why tests are given in the manner they are, what projects are geared to produce, and how instructor feedback can be helpful rather than these instruction designs feeling oppressive or pointless to students (A, 603; S, 14, 311, 315, 318). Communication and creative, goal-oriented design and evaluation are good presentation tips whether the class meets in-person or online.

Effective Approaches to Online Learning

For online learning to be considered supplemental as well as operational and neo-traditional is becoming commonplace (S, 259; W, 83). Many instructors and institutions use complete online courses and programs as a part of their mainstream offerings (A, 604). Yet, this learning mode is still relatively new, and the field continues to learn more about how traditional theories of learning coincide with distance learning and learning enhanced by technology (A, 604). According to Arghode et al. (605), the five theories of learning from past traditional concepts they studied are not transferable as effective theories for online learning. The above study calls for additional research in theories explicitly designed for distance learners (605). However, many advantages to online learning have been discovered in the relatively short lifespan of the model (A, 604; S, 96). Some of these advantages, according to research from 2015, include a preference for the self-directedness the model provides, increased flexibility in schedule, a particular student autonomy combined with instructor availability that does not exist in traditional frameworks, and, most of all, the data shows that students report preferring the choice the model provides (A, 604). With these advantages in mind, the prevailing attitude towards online learning is that it should be planned for a prepared for in a similar fashion as traditional/in-person courses, with the key difference being in how students and instructors interact (S, 259). It remains true that students must first know how to learn before showing success in either model of instruction (S, 302). Therefore, much of online learning is representative of traditional models. Still, the questions of technology permanence, virtual presence, and the space/time gap should be considered when opting for this model (W, 83-84). There is also the added note of difficulty in managing remediation and gatekeeping ethically with online learning (S, 96).

Screening, Remediation, and Gatekeeping Functions Relevant to Teaching

Regardless of the mode of instruction, there is always a need to be mindful of the responsibility of instructors and faculty to be gatekeepers regarding screening and remediation (F, 209); a counselor education program is no different. This does not just apply to watching for catching students cheating (F, 210). This also applies to the emotional, mental, and relational ability to continue in a counselor education program (F, 210; W, 125). The good news is that the qualities required to do remediation well are qualities counselor educators have been honing during their careers (F, 210). This means that counselors should be able to handle a counselor education program's remediation and gatekeeping responsibilities well. The resounding admonition on this topic, however skilled one is, is to rely on teams of peers and the institutional guidelines and accrediting body in setting standards, creating discussion-making models, and assessing the disposition of students to remain in programs and succeed at the outset (F, 209, 210, 221, 222; S, 100). As is their bent, West et al. lean into the interpersonal nature of counselor education to call for understanding and managing these relationships, whatever the interaction calls for (125). Good management of these relationships calls for reducing pressure to cheat (S, 98), modeling and encouraging honesty throughout the relationship (S, 99), and starting the screening process before admission (F, 222). One should also consider including courses in the curriculum that aid in student success (F, 222) and researching the behaviors for which decision-making models are designed to remediate—then creating assessments to measure the severity of students' disposition (F, 210, 222). All these aspects of gatekeeping can be accomplished through professional relationships and with a purpose (S, 101). After all, the goal is learning, and instructors should facilitate learning rather than inhibit learning.

Assessment of Learning

But how do we know if a student is learning or not? Assessments come in all shapes and sizes and can be administered in person or through technology (A, 605). The question is about more than just the reliability of the assessment but rather the type of assessment that measures the goals and objectives of the course (A, 74; W, 140-141). Instructors should be aware that evaluations communicate to students about the future of their performance (S, 126). Students look to grades and instructor feedback to revise and remedy habits and skills (S, 126). While testing in the traditional sense of standardized multiple-choice tests is a valid measure of performance (S, 76-83), other, more appropriate measures exist to accomplish the greater goal of facilitating learning (S, 83). Learning is not only facilitated as instructors provide feedback to students but also with assessments of instructor performance (S, 333), student peer assessment (S, 81), assessing programs based on accrediting body standards as a critical measure of overall success (S, 76), and of students' emotional health, social/cultural competencies, and disposition for success in a program (F, 222).

Emerging counselor educators should be aware of the changing landscape of assessment (W, 107). Many new platforms utilizing technology exist and are being created daily for a more effective way to give feedback (A, 605; S, 77, 76-83, 107; W, 107, 140). This mindfulness mindset with assessment goes beyond choosing the type of assessment as well (W, 142). Creating the kind of environment conducive to learning and growth is incumbent upon the instructor, not the student (W, 142). Using strengths-based assessment and feedback with students and recognizing that learning depends on the learning environment as much as anything will improve the outcomes of courses, which is what assessment tells us (W, 142). The goal is learning, but not at any cost.

Ethical and Cultural Issues Related to Counselor Preparation

Academic scholarship is not immune to poor behavior. Nor is it carried out in a vacuum. Counselor educators must be as aware of ethics and culture in the classroom as they are in the office. Counselor educators are also responsible for teaching emerging counselors how to be culturally competent and ethically accountable (F, 210; S, 150, 327, 169; W, 153, 154-156, 158). The encouragement from the sources is that, as counselors, instructors have the tools and training necessary to be culturally competent and ethically responsible and to teach others the same tools and skills (S, 320, 327). As instructors respond individually to concerns over these two essential teaching areas, they can offer individual solutions and decisions that help students feel respected and honored (S, 150, 157, 169; W, 153, 154, 158). Teaching cultural competency and ethical behavior starts with the instructors' model and continued learning (S, 150, 169). As instructors lead with mindfulness that seeks awareness of what is being communicated verbally, non-verbally, through lecture, or group interaction, they can facilitate how to broach cultural awkwardness and ethical dilemmas (F, 210; S, 150, 169; W, 153). Whether an instructor is leading students or emerging counselors through the continuum of assessment for cultural competencies provided by West et al. (154-156) or if she is teaching through ethical dilemmas and discussion-making based on the American Counseling Association's ethical guidelines from 2014, these proficiencies can be taught (W, 158). Ethical considerations guide effective relationships in and out of the classroom (F, 210). And teaching doesn't just happen in the traditional ways we have discussed. It also occurs in mentoring relationships.

The Role of Mentoring in Counselor Education

Teachers can be powerful influencers of culture and theory. They can also be powerful influencers in people's choices and directions (W, 42). Monitoring the power differential in the

teacher/student relationship is an essential ethical awareness. However, the teacher/student relationship can and should sometimes extend beyond surface classroom interaction (W, 42). It is also good to be aware when students perceive us as mentors and not dismiss those expectations (W, 160). In these situations, we can harm students' growth, efficacy, and regulation by simply missing the opportunity to be intentional with them (W, 163). In counselor education, the supervisory role is often the most obvious of mentoring roles (W, 42). While this role is essential and can offer opportunities for objective decision-making with proteges (W, 42), mentors must remember to be good social role models and not set goals for nor make decisions for proteges (S, 293; W, 42). Staying aware of oneself as a mentor, educator, and counselor is likely the most crucial tip from these sources (S, 297; W, 170). To be an effective mentor, one must be an effective part of culture and society. Counselor educators as mentors must remember to examine their thinking and behavior and reflect on their self-regulation and intrapersonal health to be effective (S, 177-186, 297; W, 170).

Much mentoring in counselor education may occur in the supervisory role, as mentioned above, or through organic interactions and connections with students. However, educators should stay aware of ways to connect to potential proteges through alternative avenues (S, 177-186). Learning to be accessible to students, presenting ourselves as mentors, involving ourselves in students' lives outside the classroom, staying mindful of how we are impacting students inside and outside of the classroom, and participating in the professional community are all ways to encourage and solicit mentoring relationships (S, 168-170, 177-186; W, 42).

Conclusion

Building relationships in creative and intentional ways through mindfulness and sensitivity is the overarching theme of the sources considered here. To be effective counselor educators in these nine areas and more is not by accident nor by innate talent. These four sources have been built from years of experience and decades of research. The tips, encouragement, and admonitions contained in these sources are not, nor do they claim to be, comprehensive means to producing effective counselor educators and counselors. They are, however, clear and concise resources for doing just that.

References

- Arghode, V., Brieger, E. W., & McLean, G. N. (2017). Adult learning theories: Implications for online instruction. *European Journal of Training and Development, 41*(7), 593-609.
<https://dx.doi.org/10.1108/EJTD-02-2017-0014>
- Freeman, B. J., Garner, C. M., Scherer, R., & Trachock, K. (2019). Discovering expert perspectives on dispositions and remediation: A qualitative study. *Counselor Education & Supervision, 58*(3), 209-224. <https://dx.doi.org/10.1002/ceas.12151>
- Svinicki, M., McKeachie, W. (2014). *McKeachie's teaching tips: Strategies, research, and theory for college and university teachers* (14th ed.). Wadsworth, Inc.
- West, J., Bubenzer, D., Cox, J., & McGlothlin, J. M. (2013). *Teaching in counselor education: Engaging students in learning*. American Counseling Association.

Appendix A

Grading Rubric

Criteria	Ratings				Points
Synthesis of material	45 to >40 pts	40 to >37 pts	37 to >0 pts	0 pts	45 pts
	Advanced Shows advanced levels of evidence of comprehending course content and applicability to practice as a counselor educator.	Proficient Shows proficient evidence of comprehension of course content and applicability to practice as a counselor educator.	Developing Shows developing and little evidence of comprehension of course content and applicability to practice as a counselor educator.	Not Present	43
Quantity & Timeliness	25 to >22 pts	22 to >20 pts	20 to >0 pts	0 pts	25 pts
	Advanced Succinct summaries remain within the 250-300 word count requirement, and points are cited in the truncated format provided. Grading Rubric-Self-Evaluation included.	Proficient Succinct summaries remain within the 250-300 word count requirement, and most points are cited in the truncated format provided. Grading Rubric-Self-Evaluation included.	Developing Summaries are either not within the 250-300 word count requirement, and/or points are cited in the truncated format provided. Additionally, summaries lack pertinent material. Grading Rubric-Self-Evaluation included	Not Present	25
Mechanics & Composition	15 to >13 pts	13 to >12 pts	12 to >0 pts	0 pts	15 pts
	Advanced Paper is free of errors in spelling, grammar, or punctuation. Writing style displays exceptional composition with all of the following elements: coherent, cohesive, effective sentence/paragraph structures, logical progression, and transitions	Proficient Few errors in spelling, grammar, or punctuation. Clear writing style displaying basic composition with most of the following elements: coherent, cohesive, effective sentence/paragraph structures, logical progression, and transitions	Developing Pervasive errors in spelling, grammar, or punctuation. Writing includes pervasive errors in multiple categories: coherent, cohesive, effective sentence/paragraph structures, logical progression, and transitions.	Not Present	13
APA	15 to >13 pts	13 to >12 pts	12 to >0 pts	0 pts	15 pts
	Advanced Citations are appropriately implemented and are formatted per APA (truncated format allowed). All of the references are strong, legitimate academic sources and are correctly formatted per APA. Overall paper is formatted per APA: running head, page numbers, title page, spacing, indentions, margins, and headings.	Proficient Minor errors regarding appropriate implementation and/or APA formatting of citations. Most references are from legitimate academic sources; few formatting errors according to APA. Few errors in paper format per APA: running head, page numbers, title page, spacing, indentions, margins, and headings.	Developing Pervasive errors regarding appropriate implementation and/or APA formatting of citations. Multiple references are from questionable sources; multiple formatting errors according to APA. Multiple errors in paper format per APA: running head, page numbers, title page, spacing, indentions, margins, and headings.	Not Present	15
Total Points: 100					